

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Foreign-Policy Foundations and Strategic Autonomy - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Foreign-Policy Foundations and Strategic Autonomy	
REFRESHED TEACHING NAVIGATION — BASIC/CORE FIRST	
01 FOUNDATION — WHAT THE FOUNDATIONS OWNER HOLDS AND WHY ITS VOCABULARY Prelims: Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated	02 FOUNDATION — NATIONAL INTEREST AND THE RESULTS CHAIN THAT EVERY ANSWER MUST Prelims: Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated
03 FOUNDATION — NEHRU'S THREE ELEMENTS AND BIPAN CHANDRA'S METHOD READING Bipan Chandra's assessment in India After Independence frames	04 CORE — STRATEGIC AUTONOMY AS THE MULTIPOLAR SUCCESSOR LABEL Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing
05 CORE — MULTI-ALIGNMENT AS THE OPERATIONAL EXPRESSION OF THE SAME Evidence chain: Multi-alignment as Shashi Tharoor's operational	06 CORE — PANCHSHEEL OF 1954 AND THE EXACT AGREEMENT THAT CARRIES IT Evidence chain: Panchsheel of 1954 and its exact treaty context
07 CORE — HEDGING AGAINST NEUTRALITY, BANDWAGONING AND BALANCING Evidence chain: Hedging distinguished from neutrality, bandwagoning	08 CORE — CO-OPTION AGAINST AUTONOMOUS POSITIONING AND THE COALITION-ALLIANCE Evidence chain: Co-option against autonomous positioning as Sika's
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11 CORE — EVIDENTIARY LEVELS AND THE LEGAL-STATUS DISCIPLINE The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and	12 CORE — SAGAR OF 2015 AND MAHASAGAR OF 2025 AS DATED DECLARED VISIONS Evidence chain: SAGAR of 2015 and MAHASAGAR of 2025 as
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Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Q1. Which statement correctly identifies What this owner holds and why the whole International Relations folder depends on it?

A. This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument toolkit and the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner. B. Bipan Chandra's assessment in India After Independence frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned. C. The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve. D. Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing.

Answer: A. Explanation: This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument toolkit and the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q2. Which card should be filed under What this owner holds and why the whole International Relations folder depends on it in an International Relations answer?

A. Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing. B. This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument toolkit and the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner. C. Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus. D. Bipan Chandra's assessment in India After Independence frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned.

Answer: B. Explanation: This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument toolkit and the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q3. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of What this owner holds and why the whole International Relations folder depends on it?

A. Bipan Chandra's assessment in India After Independence frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned. B. Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in Pax Indica for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation. C. This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument toolkit and

the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner. D. Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus.

Answer: C. Explanation: This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument toolkit and the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q4. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about What this owner holds and why the whole International Relations folder depends on it?

A. Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in Pax Indica for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation. B. Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but distinct and were not adopted at the same conference. C. Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus. D. This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument toolkit and the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner.

Answer: D. Explanation: This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument toolkit and the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q5. Which statement correctly identifies National interest as the fixed starting point of the results chain?

A. The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve. B. Bipan Chandra's assessment in *India After Independence* frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned. C. Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus. D. Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing.

Answer: A. Explanation: The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q6. Which card should be filed under National interest as the fixed starting point of the results chain in an International Relations answer?

A. Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in Pax Indica for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation. B. The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve. C. Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus. D. Bipan Chandra's assessment in India After Independence frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned.

Answer: B. Explanation: The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q7. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of National interest as the fixed starting point of the results chain?

A. Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but distinct and were not adopted at the same conference. B. Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in Pax Indica for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation. C. The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve. D. Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to

non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus.

Answer: C. Explanation: The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q8. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about National interest as the fixed starting point of the results chain?

A. Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in Pax Indica for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation. B. Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but distinct and were not adopted at the same conference. C. Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them. D. The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve.

Answer: D. Explanation: The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q9. Which statement correctly identifies Nehru's three-part formulation of non-alignment?

A. Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing. B. Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus. C. Bipan Chandra's assessment in *India After Independence* frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned. D. Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in *Pax Indica* for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation.

Answer: A. Explanation: Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q10. Which card should be filed under Nehru's three-part formulation of non-alignment in an International Relations answer?

A. Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in *Pax Indica* for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation. B. Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing. C. Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus. D. Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the

preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but distinct and were not adopted at the same conference.

Answer: B. Explanation: Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q11. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Nehru's three-part formulation of non-alignment?

A. Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in Pax Indica for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation. B. Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them. C. Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing. D. Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but distinct and were not adopted at the same conference.

Answer: C. Explanation: Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q12. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Nehru's three-part formulation of non-alignment?

A. Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently. B. Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them. C. Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but distinct and were not adopted at the same conference. D. Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing.

Answer: D. Explanation: Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q13. Which statement correctly identifies Bipan Chandra's characterisation of non-alignment as a method rather than a blueprint?

A. Bipan Chandra's assessment in *India After Independence* frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned. B. Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus. C. Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but

distinct and were not adopted at the same conference. D. Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in Pax Indica for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation.

Answer: A. Explanation: Bipan Chandra's assessment in India After Independence frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q14. Which card should be filed under Bipan Chandra's characterisation of non-alignment as a method rather than a blueprint in an International Relations answer?

A. Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in Pax Indica for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation. B. Bipan Chandra's assessment in India After Independence frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned. C. Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but distinct and were not adopted at the same conference. D. Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them.

Answer: B. Explanation: Bipan Chandra's assessment in India After Independence frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q15. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Bipan Chandra's characterisation of non-alignment as a method rather than a blueprint?

A. Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them. B. Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently. C. Bipan Chandra's assessment in *India After Independence* frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned. D. Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but distinct and were not adopted at the same conference.

Answer: C. Explanation: Bipan Chandra's assessment in India After Independence frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q16. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Bipan Chandra's characterisation of non-alignment as a method rather than a blueprint?

A. Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently. B. An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's minilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership. C. Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them. D. Bipan Chandra's assessment in *India After Independence* frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that

continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned.

Answer: D. Explanation: Bipan Chandra's assessment in India After Independence frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q17. Which statement correctly identifies Strategic autonomy as the multipolar-era successor label?

A. Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus. B. Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them. C. Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in Pax Indica for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation. D. Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but distinct and were not adopted at the same conference.

Answer: A. Explanation: Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q18. Which card should be filed under Strategic autonomy as the multipolar-era successor label in an International Relations answer?

A. Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them. B. Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus. C. Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently. D. Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but distinct and were not adopted at the same conference.

Answer: B. Explanation: Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q19. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Strategic autonomy as the multipolar-era successor label?

A. An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's unilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership. B. Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them. C. Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus. D. Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as

whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently.

Answer: C. Explanation: Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q20. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Strategic autonomy as the multipolar-era successor label?

A. An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's minilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership. B. Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion. C. Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently. D. Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus.

Answer: D. Explanation: Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q21. Which statement correctly identifies Multi-alignment as Shashi Tharoor's operational expression of the same principle?

A. Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in Pax Indica for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation. B. Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but distinct and were not adopted at the same conference. C. Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them. D. Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently.

Answer: A. Explanation: Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in Pax Indica for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q22. Which card should be filed under Multi-alignment as Shashi Tharoor's operational expression of the same principle in an International Relations answer?

A. Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them. B. Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in Pax Indica for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation. C. Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently. D. An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's minilateral engagements are consistently

the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership.

Answer: B. Explanation: Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in Pax Indica for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q23. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Multi-alignment as Shashi Tharoor's operational expression of the same principle?

A. An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's unilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership. B. Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently. C. Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in Pax Indica for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation. D. Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion.

Answer: C. Explanation: Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in Pax Indica for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q24. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Multi-alignment as Shashi Tharoor's operational expression of the same principle?

A. An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's unilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership. B. The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC, BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, unilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global

engagement through universal or near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration. C. Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion. D. Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in Pax Indica for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation.

Answer: D. Explanation: Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in Pax Indica for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q25. Which statement correctly identifies Panchsheel of 1954 and its exact treaty context?

A. Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but distinct and were not adopted at the same conference. B. Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them. C. An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's minilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership. D. Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently.

Answer: A. Explanation: Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but distinct and were not adopted at the

same conference. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q26. Which card should be filed under Panchsheel of 1954 and its exact treaty context in an International Relations answer?

A. An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's unilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership. B. Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but distinct and were not adopted at the same conference. C. Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently. D. Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion.

Answer: B. Explanation: Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but distinct and were not adopted at the same conference. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q27. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Panchsheel of 1954 and its exact treaty context?

A. The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC, BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, unilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global engagement through universal or near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration. B. An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's unilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the

description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership. C. Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but distinct and were not adopted at the same conference. D. Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion.

Answer: C. Explanation: Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but distinct and were not adopted at the same conference. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q28. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Panchsheel of 1954 and its exact treaty context?

A. The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC, BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, minilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global engagement through universal or near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration. B. The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be upgraded into one another without a date. C. Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion. D. Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but distinct and were not adopted at the same conference.

Answer: D. Explanation: Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but distinct and were not adopted at the same conference. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q29. Which statement correctly identifies Hedging distinguished from neutrality, bandwagoning and balancing?

A. Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them. B. An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's minilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership. C. Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently. D. Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion.

Answer: A. Explanation: Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q30. Which card should be filed under Hedging distinguished from neutrality, bandwagoning and balancing in an International Relations answer?

A. Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion. B. Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of

them. C. The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC, BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, minilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global engagement through universal or near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration. D. An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's minilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership.

Answer: B. Explanation: Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q31. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Hedging distinguished from neutrality, bandwagoning and balancing?

A. The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be upgraded into one another without a date. B. Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion. C. Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them. D. The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC, BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, minilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global engagement through universal or near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration.

Answer: C. Explanation: Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power

simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q32. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Hedging distinguished from neutrality, bandwagoning and balancing?

A. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR. B. The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be upgraded into one another without a date. C. The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC, BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, unilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global engagement through universal or near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration. D. Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them.

Answer: D. Explanation: Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q33. Which statement correctly identifies Co-option against autonomous positioning as Sikri's central strategic choice?

A. Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently. B. An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's minilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership. C. Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion. D. The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC, BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, minilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global engagement through universal or near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration.

Answer: A. Explanation: Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q34. Which card should be filed under Co-option against autonomous positioning as Sikri's central strategic choice in an International Relations answer?

A. Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion. B. Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently. C. The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is

participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be upgraded into one another without a date. D. The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC, BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, minilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global engagement through universal or near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration.

Answer: B. Explanation: Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q35. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Co-option against autonomous positioning as Sikri's central strategic choice?

A. The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC, BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, minilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global engagement through universal or near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration. B. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR. C. Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently. D. The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be upgraded into one another without a date.

Answer: C. Explanation: Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an

independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q36. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Co-option against autonomous positioning as Sikri's central strategic choice?

A. The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of External Affairs bilateral document dated January 2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited. B. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR. C. The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be upgraded into one another without a date. D. Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently.

Answer: D. Explanation: Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q37. Which statement correctly identifies Issue-based coalition against treaty alliance?

A. An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's minilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership. B. The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC, BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, minilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global engagement through universal or near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration. C. Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion. D. The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be upgraded into one another without a date.

Answer: A. Explanation: An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's minilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q38. Which card should be filed under Issue-based coalition against treaty alliance in an International Relations answer?

A. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR. B. An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's minilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership. C. The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC,

BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, minilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global engagement through universal or near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration. D. The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be upgraded into one another without a date.

Answer: B. Explanation: An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's minilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q39. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Issue-based coalition against treaty alliance?

A. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR. B. The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of External Affairs bilateral document dated January 2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited. C. An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's minilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership. D. The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be upgraded into one another without a date.

Answer: C. Explanation: An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding

collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's minilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q40. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Issue-based coalition against treaty alliance?

A. The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of External Affairs bilateral document dated January 2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited. B. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR. C. The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy. D. An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's minilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership.

Answer: D. Explanation: An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's minilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q41. Which statement correctly identifies Principle and interest as complementary rather than opposed?

A. Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion. B. The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC, BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, minilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global engagement through universal or near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the

World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration. C. The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be upgraded into one another without a date. D. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR.

Answer: A. Explanation: Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q42. Which card should be filed under Principle and interest as complementary rather than opposed in an International Relations answer?

A. The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of External Affairs bilateral document dated January 2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited. B. Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion. C. The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be upgraded into one another without a date. D. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by

themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR.

Answer: B. Explanation: Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q43. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Principle and interest as complementary rather than opposed?

A. The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy. B. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR. C. Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion. D. The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of External Affairs bilateral document dated January 2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited.

Answer: C. Explanation: Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q44. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Principle and interest as complementary rather than opposed?

A. The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of External Affairs bilateral document dated January 2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited. B. The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy. C. The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India. D. Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion.

Answer: D. Explanation: Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q45. Which statement correctly identifies The five levels of engagement and the instrument toolkit?

A. The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC, BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, minilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global engagement through universal or near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration. B. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR. C. The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one

reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be upgraded into one another without a date. D. The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of External Affairs bilateral document dated January 2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited.

Answer: A. Explanation: The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC, BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, minilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global engagement through universal or near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q46. Which card should be filed under The five levels of engagement and the instrument toolkit in an International Relations answer?

A. The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of External Affairs bilateral document dated January 2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited. B. The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC, BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, minilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global engagement through universal or near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration. C. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR. D. The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because

the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy.

Answer: B. Explanation: The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC, BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, minilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global engagement through universal or near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q47. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The five levels of engagement and the instrument toolkit?

A. The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of External Affairs bilateral document dated January 2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited. B. The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy. C. The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC, BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, minilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global engagement through universal or near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration. D. The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India.

Answer: C. Explanation: The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC, BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, minilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global engagement through universal or near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q48. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The five levels of engagement and the instrument toolkit?

A. The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy. B. Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the boundary discipline is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised must not be quoted as a settled one. C. The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India. D. The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC, BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, minilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global engagement through universal or near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration.

Answer: D. Explanation: The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC, BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, minilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global engagement through universal or near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q49. Which statement correctly identifies Evidentiary levels and the legal-status gap?

A. The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be upgraded into one another without a date. B. The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of

External Affairs bilateral document dated January 2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited. C. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR. D. The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy.

Answer: A. Explanation: The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be upgraded into one another without a date. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q50. Which card should be filed under Evidentiary levels and the legal-status gap in an International Relations answer?

A. The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy. B. The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be upgraded into one another without a date. C. The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of External Affairs bilateral document dated January 2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited. D. The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year

Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India.

Answer: B. Explanation: The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be upgraded into one another without a date. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q51. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Evidentiary levels and the legal-status gap?

A. Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the boundary discipline is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised must not be quoted as a settled one. B. The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy. C. The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be upgraded into one another without a date. D. The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India.

Answer: C. Explanation: The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be

upgraded into one another without a date. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q52. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Evidentiary levels and the legal-status gap?

A. The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India. B. The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security Council reform being the standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one. C. Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the boundary discipline is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised must not be quoted as a settled one. D. The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be upgraded into one another without a date.

Answer: D. Explanation: The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be upgraded into one another without a date. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q53. Which statement correctly identifies SAGAR of 2015 and MAHASAGAR of 2025 as declared visions?

A. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR. B. The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy. C. The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India. D. The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of External Affairs bilateral document dated January 2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited.

Answer: A. Explanation: SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q54. Which card should be filed under SAGAR of 2015 and MAHASAGAR of 2025 as declared visions in an International Relations answer?

A. Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the boundary discipline is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised must not be quoted as a settled one. B. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology

sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR. C. The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India. D. The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy.

Answer: B. Explanation: SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q55. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of SAGAR of 2015 and MAHASAGAR of 2025 as declared visions?

A. Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the boundary discipline is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised must not be quoted as a settled one. B. The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India. C. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR. D. The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than

during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security Council reform being the standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one.

Answer: C. Explanation: SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q56. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about SAGAR of 2015 and MAHASAGAR of 2025 as declared visions?

A. The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security Council reform being the standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one. B. Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the boundary discipline is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised must not be quoted as a settled one. C. The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely The India Way and Why Bharat Matters, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer. D. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR.

Answer: D. Explanation: SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a

shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q57. Which statement correctly identifies The Voice of Global South Summit as autonomous agenda-setting?

A. The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of External Affairs bilateral document dated January 2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited. B. The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India. C. The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy. D. Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the boundary discipline is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised must not be quoted as a settled one.

Answer: A. Explanation: The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of External Affairs bilateral document dated January 2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q58. Which card should be filed under The Voice of Global South Summit as autonomous agenda-setting in an International Relations answer?

A. Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the boundary discipline is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised must not be quoted as a settled one. B. The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of External Affairs bilateral document dated January

2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited. C. The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security Council reform being the standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one. D. The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India.

Answer: B. Explanation: The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of External Affairs bilateral document dated January 2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q59. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The Voice of Global South Summit as autonomous agenda-setting?

A. Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the boundary discipline is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised must not be quoted as a settled one. B. The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely The India Way and Why Bharat Matters, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer. C. The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of External Affairs bilateral document dated January 2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited. D. The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security Council reform being the standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too

visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one.

Answer: C. Explanation: The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of External Affairs bilateral document dated January 2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q60. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The Voice of Global South Summit as autonomous agenda-setting?

A. The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely The India Way and Why Bharat Matters, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer. B. This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument toolkit and the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner. C. The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security Council reform being the standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one. D. The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of External Affairs bilateral document dated January 2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited.

Answer: D. Explanation: The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of External Affairs bilateral document dated January 2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q61. Which statement correctly identifies The autonomy-dependence trade-off as the doctrine's real cost?

A. The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy. B. The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India. C. Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the boundary discipline is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised must not be quoted as a settled one. D. The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security Council reform being the standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q62. Which card should be filed under The autonomy-dependence trade-off as the doctrine's real cost in an International Relations answer?

A. Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the boundary discipline is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised must not be quoted as a settled one. B. The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy. C. The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains

question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely *The India Way* and *Why Bharat Matters*, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer. D. The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security Council reform being the standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q63. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The autonomy-dependence trade-off as the doctrine's real cost?

A. The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely *The India Way* and *Why Bharat Matters*, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer. B. This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument toolkit and the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner. C. The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy. D. The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security Council reform being the

standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q64. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The autonomy-dependence trade-off as the doctrine's real cost?

A. The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve. B. The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely The India Way and Why Bharat Matters, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer. C. This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument toolkit and the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner. D. The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q65. Which statement correctly identifies The 2025-26 hedging stress test with dated, reversible measures?

A. The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India. B. Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the boundary discipline is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised must not be quoted as a settled one. C. The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security Council reform being the standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one. D. The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely The India Way and Why Bharat Matters, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q66. Which card should be filed under The 2025-26 hedging stress test with dated, reversible measures in an International Relations answer?

A. This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument toolkit and the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner. B. The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called

the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India. C. The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security Council reform being the standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one. D. The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely The India Way and Why Bharat Matters, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q67. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The 2025-26 hedging stress test with dated, reversible measures?

A. The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve. B. The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely The India Way and Why Bharat Matters, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer. C. The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and

secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India. D. This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument toolkit and the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q68. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The 2025-26 hedging stress test with dated, reversible measures?

A. This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument toolkit and the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner. B. Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing. C. The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve. D. The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025;

the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q69. Which statement correctly identifies Gulf energy exposure as a simultaneous vulnerability and lever?

A. Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the boundary discipline is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised must not be quoted as a settled one. B. This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument toolkit and the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner. C. The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security Council reform being the standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one. D. The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely The India Way and Why Bharat Matters, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer.

Answer: A. Explanation: Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the boundary discipline is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised must not be quoted as a settled one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q70. Which card should be filed under Gulf energy exposure as a simultaneous vulnerability and lever in an International Relations answer?

A. The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve. B. Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the boundary discipline is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised must not be quoted as a settled one. C. This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument toolkit and the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner. D. The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely The India Way and Why Bharat Matters, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer.

Answer: B. Explanation: Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the boundary discipline is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised must not be quoted as a settled one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q71. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Gulf energy exposure as a simultaneous vulnerability and lever?

A. Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing. B. The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve. C. Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests

in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the boundary discipline is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised must not be quoted as a settled one. D. This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument toolkit and the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner.

Answer: C. Explanation: Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the boundary discipline is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised must not be quoted as a settled one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q72. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Gulf energy exposure as a simultaneous vulnerability and lever?

A. Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing. B. The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve. C. Bipan Chandra's assessment in *India After Independence* frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned. D. Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the boundary discipline is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised must not be quoted as a settled one.

Answer: D. Explanation: Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the

boundary discipline is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised must not be quoted as a settled one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q73. Which statement correctly identifies NAM's narrowed salience and the limits of coalition leadership?

A. The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security Council reform being the standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one. B. The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve. C. The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely The India Way and Why Bharat Matters, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer. D. This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument toolkit and the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security Council reform being the standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q74. Which card should be filed under NAM's narrowed salience and the limits of coalition leadership in an International Relations answer?

A. This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument toolkit and the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner. B. The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security Council reform being the standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one. C. The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve. D. Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security Council reform being the standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q75. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of NAM's narrowed salience and the limits of coalition leadership?

A. The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve. B. Bipan Chandra's assessment in *India After Independence* frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned. C. The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under

multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security Council reform being the standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one. D. Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security Council reform being the standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q76. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about NAM's narrowed salience and the limits of coalition leadership?

A. Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing. B. Bipan Chandra's assessment in *India After Independence* frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned. C. Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus. D. The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security Council reform being the standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security

Council reform being the standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q77. Which statement correctly identifies Honest question ownership and the recurring analytical gaps applied here?

A. The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely *The India Way* and *Why Bharat Matters*, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer. B. Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing. C. This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument toolkit and the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner. D. The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely *The India Way* and *Why Bharat Matters*, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q78. Which card should be filed under Honest question ownership and the recurring analytical gaps applied here in an International Relations answer?

A. The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve. B. The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely The India Way and Why Bharat Matters, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer. C. Bipan Chandra's assessment in India After Independence frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned. D. Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely The India Way and Why Bharat Matters, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q79. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Honest question ownership and the recurring analytical gaps applied here?

A. Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing. B. Bipan Chandra's assessment in India After Independence frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned. C. The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent

demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely *The India Way* and *Why Bharat Matters*, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer. D. Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely *The India Way* and *Why Bharat Matters*, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q80. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Honest question ownership and the recurring analytical gaps applied here?

A. Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus. B. Bipan Chandra's assessment in *India After Independence* frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned. C. Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in *Pax Indica* for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation. D. The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely *The India Way* and *Why Bharat Matters*, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and

sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely *The India Way* and *Why Bharat Matters*, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED OBJECTIVE-ONLY PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT

One objective demand is routed to this topic in the audited routing ledgers and it is reproduced here exactly as the ledger records it: 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely *The India Way* and *Why Bharat Matters*. The owner's own integration block records that the official 2024 Prelims Set-A key is present locally, yet it states expressly that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, and that rule is preserved here without exception, so no answer letter appears anywhere in this package. No General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and the owners instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted onto an unrelated question, so no Mains demand card is manufactured for this topic and no adjacent question is claimed as its property. The locally held OCR-searchable official General Studies papers were read only to confirm printed wording; no question was invented from them, no stem was paraphrased into an apparent routing, and no marking scheme or page precision was imported. Every model solution in the original practice section below is original work written to the repository's examiner-grade standard using the claim, named evidence, analysis and qualification pattern, and none of them reproduces or claims an official answer.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "VERIFIED OBJECTIVE-ONLY PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the International Relations demand in "VERIFIED OBJECTIVE-ONLY PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT".

Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** Define the foreign-policy concept and distinguish the nearest doctrine, grouping, treaty or operational category. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** Map India's interests, capabilities and constraints against the partner's agency at bilateral, regional and systemic levels. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 3. Claim and named evidence:** Identify the exact treaty, institution, corridor, agreement, operation or summit with membership, mandate, date and status. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 4. Claim and named evidence:** Trace strategic objective, selected instrument, implementing actors, resources, bottleneck, output and outcome. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

5. **Claim and named evidence:** Use named India-centric diplomatic, security, trade, connectivity, diaspora or development evidence without event-listing. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
6. **Claim and named evidence:** Test dependence, escalation, legitimacy, domestic distribution, financing, partner divergence, alternatives and residual risk. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the International Relations demand in "VERIFIED OBJECTIVE-ONLY PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT".

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "VERIFIED OBJECTIVE-ONLY PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

OWNER PYQ LEDGER EXTRACTS

9. PYQ application

- ANALYSIS: No GS-II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names

"strategic autonomy," "non-alignment" or "multi-alignment." State this honestly. Several adjacent PYQs (2024 Q9 on West-China-India supply chains; 2025 Q10 on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism) implicitly require the strategic-autonomy vocabulary developed here as the underlying analytical lens, even though this topic is not itself the named subject of a question.

Recent PYQ Integration (2024-2025)

Status: 2024-2025 question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2024-2025.md. **Answer-key rule:** The official 2024-2025 Prelims Set-A keys are present in the repository and CSAT Set-A keys are supplied; even so, no option or answer is recorded or inferred in this integration.

- **Years represented:** 2024
- **Paper(s):** Prelims GS-I
- **Routed question demands:** 1

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2024	Prelims GS-I	86	Books authored by S. Jaishankar ('The India Way', 'Why Bharat Matters')	Objective question; official Set-A key available locally, answer not inferred	Key available locally (official Set-A answer key present); answer not recorded here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.

What this owner must now support

- Books authored by S. Jaishankar ('The India Way', 'Why Bharat Matters')

This block integrates the 2024-2025 examinable demand and paper metadata. It is kept separate from the 2018-2023 block and does not convert an unkeyed/answer-free objective question into a solved answer.

10. PYQ-based analytical application

- ANALYSIS: No GS-II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy or multi-alignment. A strong analytical answer on India's general foreign-policy orientation should nonetheless:

1. State the continuing principle (independent, interest-based decision-making) before naming any era-specific label.
2. Distinguish hedging from neutrality/equidistance explicitly.
3. Cite one concrete example of simultaneous, non-exclusive engagement (e.g., US-Russia, or Global South leadership alongside major-power partnership).
4. Acknowledge the autonomy-dependence trade-off as a genuine limitation, not merely assert autonomy as costless.

ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS

Question: Distinguish non-alignment, strategic autonomy and multi-alignment as successive framings of one underlying foreign-policy principle. Answer in about 150 words.

Model thesis: The three labels express one continuing principle of independent, interest-based decision-making, so the answer must define each label with its own source, show what changed in the external context rather than in the method, and close by testing any engagement against whether it preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing.
- Bipan Chandra's assessment in *India After Independence* frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned.
- Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus.
- Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in *Pax Indica* for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation.

Qualified conclusion: The three labels express one continuing principle of independent, interest-based decision-making, so the answer must define each label with its own source, show what changed in the external context rather than in the method, and close by testing any engagement against whether it preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "Distinguish non-alignment, strategic autonomy and multi-alignment as successive framings of...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The three labels express one continuing principle of independent, interest-based decision-making, so the answer must define each label with its own source, show what changed in the external context rather than in the method, and close by testing any engagement against whether it preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue.

Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** Bipan Chandra's assessment in *India After Independence* frames non-alignment as not a blueprint for policy but an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar by which the young nation could steer its course, which explains why the doctrine could survive the disappearance of the bipolar order that produced it; the analytical payoff is that continuity in Indian foreign policy is continuity of method and not continuity of partner set, so a change of partners is evidence of the method working rather than evidence of the doctrine being abandoned. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 3. Claim and named evidence:** Strategic autonomy is recorded in the owners as the continuing successor concept to non-alignment in a multipolar, post-Cold-War world, defined as the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus rather than by bloc discipline, and it is expressly distinguished from neutrality, which implies equidistance or non-participation, because autonomy permits active and asymmetric engagement with several actors at once; Rajiv Sikri's supporting formulation is that India has wisely diversified its foreign-policy options but must retain flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, on which there is an overwhelming national consensus. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 4. Claim and named evidence:** Multi-alignment is Tharoor's term in *Pax Indica* for engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, textually pairing the United Nations with the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies, the G77 with smaller organizations like IOR-ARC, and SAARC with ASEAN-linked processes, as simultaneous and non-exclusive commitments rather than membership of one bloc; the examinable qualification is that most of the bodies in that list are non-treaty platforms, so multi-alignment describes engagement breadth and not alliance proliferation. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and

systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The three labels express one continuing principle of independent, interest-based decision-making, so the answer must define each label with its own source, show what changed in the external context rather than in the method, and close by testing any engagement against whether it preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Distinguish non-alignment, strategic autonomy and multi-alignment as successive framings of...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS

Question: Explain why Panchsheel and non-alignment are related but analytically distinct, and why the distinction matters for an answer on India's normative vocabulary. Answer in about 150 words.

Model thesis: Panchsheel is a five-principle statement of interstate conduct located in the preamble of the India-China agreement of 29 April 1954, while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the answer must separate normative principle from strategic posture and show how principled language supports interest-based coalition building without collapsing into it.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but distinct and were not adopted at the same conference.
- Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion.
- Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing.
- This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument

toolkit and the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner.

Qualified conclusion: Panchsheel is a five-principle statement of interstate conduct located in the preamble of the India-China agreement of 29 April 1954, while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the answer must separate normative principle from strategic posture and show how principled language supports interest-based coalition building without collapsing into it.

Demand decoding: The directive **explain** requires a direct position on “Explain why Panchsheel and non-alignment are related but analytically distinct, and why the...”, every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Panchsheel is a five-principle statement of interstate conduct located in the preamble of the India-China agreement of 29 April 1954, while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the answer must separate normative principle from strategic posture and show how principled language supports interest-based coalition building without collapsing into it.

Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** Panchsheel comprises the five principles of peaceful coexistence, namely mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence, and the owners fix its exact location as the preamble of the India-China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China signed on 29 April 1954, which remains a historical normative reference still invoked in India's diplomatic vocabulary and cited in joint statements; the precision that earns marks is that Panchsheel is a set of normative principles for interstate conduct while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the two are related but distinct and were not adopted at the same conference.
Analysis: Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 3. Claim and named evidence:** Non-alignment as Nehru described it had three stated elements, namely that India has no military alliances with countries of either bloc, that India has an independent approach to foreign policy, and that India attempts to maintain friendly relations with all countries, so the doctrine was a refusal to join a Cold-War bloc rather than passivity or abstention from world affairs; the examinable precision is that the first element is about alliance membership, the second about decision-making method and the third about relationship breadth, and collapsing the three into a vague idea of neutrality loses exactly the distinction the examiner is testing. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency,

causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** This topic owns the vocabulary that every later topic in the folder borrows, namely national interest, non-alignment, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, hedging, the bilateral-regional-minilateral-multilateral instrument toolkit and the autonomy-dependence trade-off, and its distinctive feature is that it is simultaneously conceptual and structurally examinable: the owners record that no General Studies Paper II Mains demand in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, while one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I is routed to it, so it must be learned as the structuring lens for adjacent questions rather than as a stand-alone question bank; the constitutional basis in Article 51 of the Directive Principles belongs to the Polity owner and the Cold-War chronology of the Non-Aligned Movement's founding belongs to the World History owner. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Panchsheel is a five-principle statement of interstate conduct located in the preamble of the India-China agreement of 29 April 1954, while non-alignment is a bloc-avoidance posture, so the answer must separate normative principle from strategic posture and show how principled language supports interest-based coalition building without collapsing into it.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Explain why Panchsheel and non-alignment are related but analytically distinct, and why the...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS

Question: Examine the claim that strategic autonomy is best understood as a method of instrument selection rather than as a fixed alliance preference. Answer in about 250 words.

Model thesis: Autonomy is a method because the owners fix a five-level instrument toolkit and an evidentiary hierarchy that force each interest to be routed to the level that suits it, so the examination must run the results chain, name the level, cite one dated instrument with its exact evidentiary level, and close with the constraint that bounds the claim.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve.
- The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC, BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, minilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global engagement through universal or

near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration.

- The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be upgraded into one another without a date.
- Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently.

Qualified conclusion: Autonomy is a method because the owners fix a five-level instrument toolkit and an evidentiary hierarchy that force each interest to be routed to the level that suits it, so the examination must run the results chain, name the level, cite one dated instrument with its exact evidentiary level, and close with the constraint that bounds the claim.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "Examine the claim that strategic autonomy is best understood as a method of instrument...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Autonomy is a method because the owners fix a five-level instrument toolkit and an evidentiary hierarchy that force each interest to be routed to the level that suits it, so the examination must run the results chain, name the level, cite one dated instrument with its exact evidentiary level, and close with the constraint that bounds the claim.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** The Master Framework of this folder defines national interest as the set of security, economic-growth and resource, technology, diaspora-welfare, reputation and rule-shaping, and strategic-autonomy goals that guide external conduct, and it fixes the answer chain as interest, then external context or actor, then instrument chosen, then verified outcome, then constraint or trade-off, then calibrated way forward; the operational consequence is that an answer which opens with a country list or a summit list has skipped the only step that makes the rest of the analysis evaluable, because the instrument can only be judged against the interest it was chosen to serve. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The Master Framework fixes five levels, namely bilateral engagement through summit visits, joint statements and defence or trade agreements, regional engagement through neighbourhood or geographic groupings such as SAARC, BIMSTEC, IORA and the Central Asia Dialogue, minilateral engagement through small non-treaty issue coalitions such as the Quad, I2U2, RIC and IBSA, multilateral or global engagement through universal or near-universal bodies such as the United Nations, the World Trade Organization, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank and the G20, and diaspora or people-to-people engagement through the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation programme and consular welfare diplomacy; the framework also records that one issue is frequently worked at more than one level at the

same time, so naming the level and justifying it is a scoring step rather than decoration. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

3. **Claim and named evidence:** The Master Framework's instrument table separates binding and non-binding outputs by naming the exact stage each one reaches, so a treaty or agreement binds once ratified, a charter binds member states once in force, a joint statement or vision document is a political commitment and not a treaty, a declaration is political or normative rather than legally binding, a memorandum of understanding is a statement of intent that is not self-executing, a corridor memorandum is a framework of intent rather than evidence of an operating segment, a dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself, and partner or observer status is participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; the framework's stated exam trap is that agreed, signed or in force, and delivered are three different claims that must never be upgraded into one another without a date. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Sikri frames the core strategic choice explicitly as whether India wants to be co-opted into the existing international structures while retaining flexibility in order to be able to pursue an independent foreign policy, and the owners record this as the operational test to apply to any specific bilateral or multilateral decision; the two options are not fully exclusive in practice, which is precisely why the distinction is analytically useful, because it converts an evaluative question about a partnership into a testable question about whether the engagement preserved India's freedom to decide the next issue independently. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Autonomy is a method because the owners fix a five-level instrument toolkit and an evidentiary hierarchy that force each interest to be routed to the level that suits it, so the examination must run the results chain, name the level, cite one dated instrument with its exact evidentiary level, and close with the constraint that bounds the claim.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Examine the claim that strategic autonomy is best understood as a method of instrument...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS

Question: Examine hedging as India's operational method toward competing major powers, and state the conditions under which it becomes costly. Answer in about 250 words.

Model thesis: Hedging is the simultaneous deepening of several partnerships on separate issue tracks rather than equidistance, so the examination must define it against bandwagoning and balancing, use the dated 2025-26 sequence as the stress test, and qualify it with the autonomy-dependence trade-off and the sanctions-obligation distinction.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them.
- An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's minilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership.
- The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy.
- The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India.

Qualified conclusion: Hedging is the simultaneous deepening of several partnerships on separate issue tracks rather than equidistance, so the examination must define it against bandwagoning and balancing, use the dated 2025-26 sequence as the stress test, and qualify it with the autonomy-dependence trade-off and the sanctions-obligation distinction.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "Examine hedging as India's operational method toward competing major powers, and state the...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Hedging is the simultaneous deepening of several partnerships on separate issue tracks rather than equidistance, so the examination must define it against bandwagoning and balancing, use the dated 2025-26 sequence as the stress test, and qualify it with the autonomy-dependence trade-off and the sanctions-obligation distinction.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and the owners record that India's minilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the Master Framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Hedging is the simultaneous deepening of several partnerships on separate issue tracks rather than equidistance, so the examination must define it against bandwagoning and balancing, use the dated 2025-26 sequence as the stress test, and qualify it with the autonomy-dependence trade-off and the sanctions-obligation distinction.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write

four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For “Examine hedging as India's operational method toward competing major powers, and state the...”, replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS

Question: Assess whether India's declared Global South visions and convening platforms strengthen strategic autonomy or merely restate it. Answer in about 300 words.

Model thesis: Declared visions and convened platforms strengthen autonomy only to the extent that they demonstrate independent agenda-setting while remaining honestly labelled as visions rather than treaties, so the assessment must date SAGAR and MAHASAGAR, date the three Voice of Global South Summit editions, and close with the recorded limit that convening does not by itself guarantee an institutional outcome.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR.
- The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of External Affairs bilateral document dated January 2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited.
- The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security Council reform being the standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one.
- Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion.

Qualified conclusion: Declared visions and convened platforms strengthen autonomy only to the extent that they demonstrate independent agenda-setting while remaining honestly labelled as visions rather than treaties, so the assessment must date SAGAR and MAHASAGAR, date the three Voice of Global South Summit editions, and close with the recorded limit that convening does not by itself guarantee an institutional outcome.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on “Assess whether India's declared Global South visions and convening platforms strengthen...”, every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Declared visions and convened platforms strengthen autonomy only to the extent that they demonstrate independent agenda-setting while remaining honestly labelled as visions rather than treaties, so the assessment must date SAGAR and MAHASAGAR, date the three Voice of Global South Summit editions, and close with the recorded limit that convening does not by itself guarantee an institutional outcome.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, and on 12 March 2025, again in Mauritius at Port Louis, the Prime Minister announced that India's vision for the Global South would be going beyond SAGAR and would be MAHASAGAR, standing for Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions, encompassing trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future, delivered through technology sharing, concessional loan and grants; the owners are explicit that both are declared visions and not treaties, that they create no obligations by themselves, and that the 2025 announcement extends scope while reaffirming that India is moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region, so MAHASAGAR did not replace or supersede SAGAR. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The Voice of Global South Summit has had three editions recorded in the owners, held on 12 to 13 January 2023, on 17 November 2023 and on 17 August 2024, all convened virtually by India, and the third edition of 17 August 2024 is referenced in a subsequent Ministry of External Affairs bilateral document dated January 2025; the owners further record that no fourth edition was officially recorded as of 3 August 2026, so the platform is the clearest verified example of India-led coalition convening under multi-alignment while any further edition or outcome requires its own dated verification before it may be cited. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** The owners record that continued membership of the Non-Aligned Movement is maintained as one platform among many under multi-alignment while the movement itself has far less contemporary relevance than during the Cold War era, and they separately record that convening or co-chairing platforms such as the Voice of Global South Summit or the G4 demonstrates agenda-setting intent without by itself guaranteeing institutional outcomes, the unresolved state of United Nations Security Council reform being the standing illustration; a further recorded constraint is that principled language can appear inconsistent if paired too visibly with an interest-driven partnership choice on the same issue, which makes sequencing and framing a real diplomatic limit rather than an academic one. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Indian diplomatic practice does not present normative commitments such as anti-colonialism, sovereign equality and Panchsheel as a trade-off against hard interests such as security, technology access and growth, and the owners note that principled language is frequently used to build coalition legitimacy for interest-based goals, for example in Global South leadership; the boundary case worth writing is that solidarity language and the interest goal of institutional voice are not separable in practice, and saying so explicitly is itself an analytical point rather than an evasion. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and

systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Declared visions and convened platforms strengthen autonomy only to the extent that they demonstrate independent agenda-setting while remaining honestly labelled as visions rather than treaties, so the assessment must date SAGAR and MAHASAGAR, date the three Voice of Global South Summit editions, and close with the recorded limit that convening does not by itself guarantee an institutional outcome.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 20 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For “Assess whether India's declared Global South visions and convening platforms strengthen...”, replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS

Question: Assess the autonomy-dependence trade-off as the binding constraint on India's diversified foreign-policy portfolio. Answer in about 300 words.

Model thesis: The trade-off binds because deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold narrows the freedom the portfolio was built to protect, so the assessment must state Sikri's caution, price the 2025-26 duty sequence as a dated and reversible third-party cost, carry the energy-dependence figures with their issuing body and financial year, and end with a calibrated diversification verdict rather than a prediction.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy.
- The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India.
- Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the boundary discipline is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised

must not be quoted as a settled one.

- The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely The India Way and Why Bharat Matters, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer.

Qualified conclusion: The trade-off binds because deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold narrows the freedom the portfolio was built to protect, so the assessment must state Sikri's caution, price the 2025-26 duty sequence as a dated and reversible third-party cost, carry the energy-dependence figures with their issuing body and financial year, and end with a calibrated diversification verdict rather than a prediction.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "Assess the autonomy-dependence trade-off as the binding constraint on India's diversified...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The trade-off binds because deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold narrows the freedom the portfolio was built to protect, so the assessment must state Sikri's caution, price the 2025-26 duty sequence as a dated and reversible third-party cost, carry the energy-dependence figures with their issuing body and financial year, and end with a calibrated diversification verdict rather than a prediction.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** The owners state that hedging is not cost-free and that deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold can erode the very autonomy the portfolio approach is meant to protect, and Sikri's own caution is recorded directly, namely that it is highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the United States without reciprocal technology-sharing; the answer-writing consequence is that a strong response must acknowledge the trade-off as a genuine limitation rather than assert autonomy as costless, because the acknowledgement is precisely what distinguishes analysis from advocacy. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The owners record a dated sequence that tests hedging directly: an additional United States duty linked to purchases of Russian oil took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February 2026, India officially called the action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025, the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit went ahead in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025, and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on 31 October 2025; the recorded reading is that hedging held but that its cost is real, priced and third-party imposed, and the Master Framework's sanctions-obligation gap adds the necessary precision that another state's unilateral measure is exposure and secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Sikri records that a Gulf diaspora of five million gives India vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region, and the owners pair that with the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell record of 88.2 per cent crude-oil import dependence in the financial year 2024-25 and about 88.7 per cent provisional in the financial year 2025-26, so energy dependence operates at the same time as a source of vulnerability and as a channel of diplomatic leverage through diaspora and investment ties; the boundary discipline

is that each figure must be carried with its issuing body, financial year and provisional status, because a provisional figure that is later revised must not be quoted as a settled one. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** The owners state plainly that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names strategic autonomy, non-alignment or multi-alignment, and they instruct that this be stated honestly rather than force-fitted, while noting that adjacent demands such as the 2024 question on the West and China's supply chain and the 2025 question on waning globalisation and sovereign nationalism implicitly require this vocabulary as the underlying lens; the audited routing ledgers additionally route one objective demand from 2024 Prelims General Studies Paper I, question 86, on books authored by S. Jaishankar, namely The India Way and Why Bharat Matters, and the owners record that the official Set-A key is present locally but that no option or answer is recorded or inferred, so the objective route is carried as a coverage requirement and never as a solved answer. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence.

Qualification: State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The trade-off binds because deepening any single partnership beyond a threshold narrows the freedom the portfolio was built to protect, so the assessment must state Sikri's caution, price the 2025-26 duty sequence as a dated and reversible third-party cost, carry the energy-dependence figures with their issuing body and financial year, and end with a calibrated diversification verdict rather than a prediction.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 20 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Assess the autonomy-dependence trade-off as the binding constraint on India's diversified...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.